Family Emergency Call Plan

The voice is not proof. The callback is.

A printable kit to set up a family safe word, practise a pause line, build a callback list and agree a money rule, before an "emergency" call ever comes.

- ✓ Safe-word setup worksheet
- ✓ Pause and callback scripts
- ✓ Fillable callback list
- ✓ Phone-side card + 4 wallet cards
- ✓ 10-minute family meeting script
- ✓ 4 practice drills
- ✓ "If we already paid" first-hour checklist

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Start here

Why a plan beats a good ear

Family-emergency scams follow one script: someone you love is hurt, arrested or stranded, they need money now, and please don't tell anyone. Often a second voice, a "lawyer" or "officer", takes over to arrange payment.

What the official guidance says

FBI (IC3 PSA I-120324-PSA, Dec 3, 2024): "Create a secret word or phrase with your family to verify their identity" and verify a caller "by hanging up the phone ... and call the phone number directly."
FTC: "don't trust the voice on the line — even if it sounds like your family member or friend."
FCC: scammers may "spoof" caller ID so a call looks like it comes from a trusted source.

Is it really AI? Sometimes the FBI says criminals use AI-generated audio to impersonate relatives. Other times it's a muffled, crying voice and panic fills in the rest. You can't reliably tell under pressure, and you don't need to. This plan works either way.

How to use this kit (about 30 minutes, once)

- Page 3: pick your safe word together, in person.
- Page 4: practise the pause line out loud until it's automatic.
- Page 5: fill in the callback list and print a copy for every older relative.
- Page 6: agree the money rule and sign it.
- Page 7: cut out the phone-side card and wallet cards.
- Page 8: run the 10-minute family meeting. Page 9: practise a drill. Page 10: keep it in case money was already sent.

Move 1: Choose a family safe word

Agree on it in person, never in a group chat or email

- Use two unrelated, ordinary words (example only, don't use it: "copper lantern"). It should be easy to say under stress and hard to guess.
- Never use anything that appears online or that a stranger could look up: pets, streets, schools, teams, birthdays, nicknames.
- Everyone who might call for help, or be called, needs to know it: grandparents, parents, teens, and a trusted neighbour if they help out.
- The real person must SAY the word. Never prompt it or give a hint ("is it something about a lantern?").
- Change it if it's ever shared outside the family, a phone is lost or stolen, or someone's email is hacked. Set a reminder to review it every 6 months.

Worksheet (fill in on paper; do NOT type the word into this PDF if you'll store it

Family members who know the word:

Date agreed: _____ Next review date (6 months): _____

Where the printed copy is kept (e.g. sealed envelope in the kitchen drawer):

_____

Optional backup question: if an older relative may forget the word under stress, also agree one question whose answer isn't anywhere online ("What did we eat after the power cut?"). The FTC suggests asking a question only the real person would know.

Move 2: The pause line and scripts

Say these out loud a few times. Words you've practised come out under stress.

The pause line (memorise this one)

"I love you. I'm going to call you right back." Then hang up. A real family member will understand. If the caller pushes, begs you to stay on, or gets angry, that pushing is your answer.

If they say "Don't tell Mom / Dad / anyone"

"In our family we always check with each other first. I'm calling you back." Secrecy is a tactic: it stops you checking. Calling someone else is exactly the right move.

If a "lawyer", "officer" or "bail agent" takes the phone

"Give me your name and office. I'll call the court or station back on a number I look up myself." Then look up the number yourself; never use one they give you.

If they ask for the safe word back, or say there's "no time"

"What's our word?" Wait. Don't offer hints. No word, no money, no matter how real it sounds.

If you want to stay on the line (e.g. you're unsure)

Ask a question only the real person knows. Meanwhile, use another phone to call the person directly.

Move 3: The callback list

Always call back on a number YOU saved, never one the caller gives you

Name / relationship	Mobile (saved in contacts)	Second contact (roommate, partn

- If you can't reach the person: call the next name. The FTC advises contacting another family member or friend, even if the caller said to keep it secret.
- Keep a printed copy next to the phone that older relatives use most. Caller ID can be faked, so the list is about who YOU call.
- Local police non-emergency number: write it here _____ (for a real arrest, check directly with the police or court, using a number you look up yourself).

Move 4: The family money rule

Scammers ask for money that's hard to get back

The FTC says fake-emergency scammers insist on payment by wire transfer, cryptocurrency, a payment app, or gift-card numbers. The FCC warns some ask to meet to collect money in person. Agree this rule now:

OUR RULE

Nobody in this family sends cash by courier, gift cards, wires, crypto or payment-app transfers because of a phone call, text or message, until we have called the person back on a saved number and they have confirmed it.

Red flags (any one means: pause and call back)

- Urgency: "right now", "before the hearing", "there's no time".
- Secrecy: "don't tell Mom", "the judge put a gag order on this".
- A handoff to an official-sounding stranger who sets the amount.
- Unusual payment: gift cards, crypto, wire, payment app, or someone coming to your home to collect cash.
- A cover story for the bank: "tell them it's for a contractor".

Signed by (everyone who agrees)

Cut-out cards

Phone-side card (top) · wallet cards (bottom); cut along the dotted lines

EMERGENCY CALL? STOP. THE VOICE IS NOT

1. **Ask: "What's our word?" (no hints)**
2. Say: "I love you. I'm calling you right back." Hang up.
3. Call them on the number saved in YOUR contacts.
4. No answer? Call the next person on our list.
5. No cash, gift cards, wires, crypto or app transfers until it's confirmed.

FAMILY CALL RULE

The voice is not proof.
Ask for our word.
"I'll call you right back."
Call a SAVED number.
No courier cash, gift cards,
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The 10-minute family meeting

A script for adult children talking with parents, or grandparents with teens

Minute 0-2: Open without fear or blame

"I read that scammers call grandparents pretending to be a grandchild in trouble. Sometimes the voice sounds real. It's not about being gullible; they're professionals. Can we set up a simple plan?"

Minute 2-5: Pick the word together

Use page 3. Let the older relative choose or approve it, so they own it. Say it out loud twice.

Minute 5-7: Practise the pause line

Role-play once: you play the panicked caller, they say "I love you, I'm calling you right back" and hang up. Then swap roles.

Minute 7-9: Callback list + money rule

Fill in page 5 together, save the numbers in their phone, and read the rule on page 6 aloud.

Minute 9-10: Make it normal

"If you ever get a call like this, calling me is never a bother, even at 3 a.m. I'd rather get ten false alarms than lose you to one scam."

Practice drills

Run one drill a month for the first few months; it takes two minutes

Drill A: The arrested grandchild

"Grandma, I got arrested, I need bail, don't tell Dad." Then a "lawyer" asks for cash by courier. Correct response: ask for the word, pause line, hang up, call the grandchild and a parent.

Drill B: The hospital call

"This is Dr. Smith. Your son was in a crash and we need a payment before surgery." Correct response: hang up, call your son, then call the hospital on a number you look up yourself.

Drill C: The text from a new number

"Hi Mum, I dropped my phone, this is my new number, can you pay a bill for me?" Correct response: call the OLD saved number, or ask the safe word by voice call.

Drill D: The "stay on the line" caller

The caller begs you not to hang up. Correct response: hang up anyway, or keep them talking while someone else calls the person on another phone.

If money was already sent: first-hour checkli

Act fast and don't be embarrassed; these are organised criminals

- Contact the bank, card issuer, payment app, wire company or gift-card company immediately; ask them to stop or reverse the payment. The FTC says the sooner you act, the better.
- If a courier came to your home, or is scheduled to, call your local police.
- Report to the FTC: ReportFraud.ftc.gov
- Report to the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center: IC3.gov
- Report to your state attorney general (the FTC recommends this too).
- For people 60+: the DOJ National Elder Fraud Hotline, 1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311).
- Write down everything now: numbers that called, names used, amounts, times, how you paid, receipts. Use the log below.
- Expect follow-up "recovery" scams: anyone who calls offering to get your money back for a fee is another scammer.

Incident log

Date / time of call	
Number(s) shown	
Names they used	
Amount and payment method	
Who I reported to (and case numbe	

Sources and notes

Checked October 19, 2026 (ET). Rules and phone numbers can change; check the source.

- FBI IC3, PSA I-120324-PSA "Criminals Use Generative Artificial Intelligence to Facilitate Financial Fraud" (Dec 3, 2024): https://www.ic3.gov/PSA/2024/PSA241203
- FTC Consumer Advice, "Scammers Use Fake Emergencies To Steal Your Money": https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/scammers-use-fake-emergencies-steal-your-money
- FTC Consumer Alert, "Scammers use AI to enhance their family emergency schemes" (Mar 2023): https://consumer.ftc.gov/consumer-alerts/2023/03/scammers-use-ai-enhance-their-family-emergency-schemes
- FCC, "'Grandparent' Scams Get More Sophisticated": https://www.fcc.gov/consumers/scam-alert/grandparent-scams-get-more-sophisticated
- FTC press release (Jun 15, 2026): people reported losing $3.5 billion to imposter scams in 2025: https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2026/06/ftc-data-show-people-reported-losing-3-point-5-billion-imposter-scams-2025
- DOJ Office for Victims of Crime, National Elder Fraud Hotline: https://ovc.ojp.gov/program/stop-elder-fraud/providing-help-restoring-hope

Important: this kit is general educational information. It isn't legal, financial or law-enforcement advice, and no plan can guarantee that a scam is prevented or money recovered. If you think someone is in real danger, call 911.

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